

Turkish QAC's: A Slack Regulator Approach

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Roadmap

- Focus in Turkish, the focus sensitive question particle -mİ
- Introducing XQX constructions/ Question-answer pairs
- Structural analysis
- Analysis of intensification effect
- Open questions
- Outlook

Focus in Turkish

- The canonical focus position in Turkish is immediately preverbal

- Nuclear pitch accent falls on the focussed constituent

- (1) Volkan dün İstanbul-a git-ti
Volkan yesterday Istanbul-DAT go-PST Broad Focus, TP focus, object focus

“Volkan went to Istanbul yesterday.”

İşsever (2006)

- (2) Volkan İstanbul-a dün git-ti.
Volkan Istanbul-DAT yesterday go-PST Narrow Focus

“Volkan went to Istanbul yesterday.”

İşsever (2006)

-mI: Focus sensitive polar question marker

- -mI is a focus sensitive polar question particle, is obligatory in questions (pure intonation is not enough)

(3) Volkan dün İstanbul-a=mı git-ti?
Volkan yesterday Istanbul-DAT=Q go-PST

“Did Volkan go to Istanbul yesterday?” İşsever (2006)

- It can attach to any constituent to create cleft-like focused polar questions

(4) Volkan İstanbul-a dün=mü git-ti?
Volkan Istanbul-DAT yesterday=Q go-PST

“Was it yesterday when Volkan went to Istanbul?” İşsever (2006)

- Can attach to any constituent, the constituent doesn't have to move to the preverbal position.
- In such cases, the nuclear pitch accent appears on the constituent -mI attaches to

(5) Volkan dün=mü İstanbul-a git-ti?
 Volkan yesterday=Q Istanbul-DAT go-PST
 “Was it yesterday that Volkan went to Istanbul?”
 İşsever (2006)

- Post-verbal cases of -mI create polarity focus

(6) Volkan dün İstanbul-a git-ti=mi?
 Volkan yesterday Istanbul-DAT go-PST=Q
 “Did Volkan go to Istanbul yesterday?”
 Kamali (2020)

-mI and its syntactic properties

- Older theories posit -mI as located in the C head and moving to the constituent with sentential focus post-syntactically
- This is not true: -mI cannot intervene between specific elements, the position is not post-syntactic

(7) A:* Ali araba=mı için gel-di?
 Ali car=Q for come-PST
 Intended: “Did Ali come for the car?”

 B: Ali araba için=mi gel-di?
 Ali car for=Q come-PST
 “Did Ali come for the car?”

- -mI's host takes scope > shows LF movement > can't be purely phonological

(8) Bugün herkes gel-me-di.

today everyone come-NEG-PST

Available: "It's not the case that everybody came today." $\neg > \forall$

Unavailable: "It's the case that nobody came today." * $\forall > \neg$

(9) Bugün herkes=mi gel-me-di?

today everyone=mI come-NEG-PST

Unavailable: "Is it not the case that everybody came today?" * $\neg > \forall$

Available: "Is it the case that nobody came today?" $\forall > \neg$

(Özyıldız, 2015, p. 6)

X=mI X Construction

- Predicates can be put in “X mI X” configuration for emphasis

(10) Context: You buy a car that is really beautiful. You want to tell your friends about it:

Guzel=mI guzel bir araba al-dim.

beautiful=Q beautiful a car buy-pst.1sg

‘I bought a BEAUTIFUL car.’ / ‘I bought a very beautiful car.’

- Verbal cases only has the “indeed” meaning (verum/polarity focus)

(11) Context: You wanted to go to Berlin but when you went, the city didn’t turn out to be how you expected it:

Berline git-tim=mI git-tim ama mutlu ol-ma-dim.

Berlin.dat go-pst.1sg=Q go-pst.1sg but happy be-neg-pst.1sg

‘I went to Berlin indeed, but it didn’t make me happy.’

Does NOT mean: ‘I went to Berlin many times.’

- Nothing can intervene between XQX, it creates a constituent

(12) * Can uzun=mu çok uzun.

John tall=Q very tall.

Intended: 'Is John tall? Yes, he is very tall' / 'John is very very tall'

(13) * Can Berline git-ti=mi belki git-ti... but it didn't make him happy.

John Berlin.dat go-pst=Q maybe go-pst...

Intended: 'Did John go to Berlin? Maybe he did, but it didn't make him happy.'

- And this construction also has some kind of a phonological limit

(14) * Can kısır-laş-tır-ıl-abil-ecek=mi kısır-laş-tır-ıl-abil-ecek.

John neutered-turn.into-caus-pass-abil-fut=Q neutered-turn.into-caus-pass-abil-fut

Intended: 'Can John be neutered, yes.' / 'John can definitely be neutered.'

- The ‘very’ inference in XQX cases are not cancellable:

(15) # Guzel=mi guzel bir araba al-dim ama çok guzel degil.
 beautiful=Q beautiful a car buy-pst.1sg but very beau not.be
 Intended: ‘I bought a BEAUTIFUL car but it’s not very beautiful.’

- XQX also scopes below negation (though the sentences still sound off)

(16) Guzel=mi guzel bir araba al-ma-dim.
 beautiful=Q beautiful a car buy-neg-pst.1sg
 ‘I didn’t buy a BEAUTIFUL car’ / ‘I didn’t buy a very beautiful car.’

(17)? Berline git-me-dim=mi git-me-dim ama mutlu-yum
 Berlin.dat go-neg-pst.1sg=Q go-neg-pst.1sg but happy.1sg
 Intended: ‘I didn’t go to Berlin indeed, but I am happy.’

- There are contexts where both can have the same truth value, and there contexts where only one form qualifies as true:

(18) Context: we are looking for people over 2.2 meters in height for a specific task. John is 1.90 and is known as very tall in his village. The speaker says:

Can uzun(=mu uzun).

John tall(=Q tall)

> He doesn't qualify as tall or tallQtall in this context

'John is (very) tall.'

(19) Context: My friend needs someone to reach the top of the cupboard, the cupboard is 1.7m tall. I suggest John to my friend since he is 1.75m

Can uzun(#=mu uzun)

John tall (#=Q tall)

> John qualifies as tall but not

tallQtall

'John is (#very) tall.. he can reach the cupboard.'

Caponigro & Davidson (2011): Question-Answer Clauses (QACs)

- A similar phenomenon is also found in American Sign Language (ASL)
- The signer asks and gives the answer in the same string, akin to “the (true) answer to the question is..”

(20) $\text{[}_{Q\text{-constituent}} \text{ JOHN BUY WHAT}, \text{[}_{A\text{-constituent}} \text{ BOOK}]}$.
‘What John bought is a book.’

(21) $\text{[}_{Q\text{-const}} \text{ MEG LAUGH}, \text{[}_{A\text{-const}} \text{ NO (MEG NOT LAUGH)}]$
‘Meg was not laughing.’

*br is brow raise, signals an interrogative

- The semantic analysis of QACs are relatively simple, they are copular constructions (copula is null) where the QAC establishes an identity between a question and its true answer.

$$\begin{aligned}
 (22) \quad & [_{VP} [_{CP} w \textit{Ans}_{STRONG} \textbf{MEG LAUGH}]] \\
 & [_{V'} e_{BE} [\textbf{NO}, (\textbf{MEG NOT LAUGH})]]] \rightsquigarrow \\
 & \lambda q[q = \lambda w_1 \neg \textbf{laugh}(w_1)(m)] (\textit{ANS}_{STRONG}(w_0)(Q_0)) \Rightarrow \\
 & \textit{ANS}_{STRONG}(w_0)(Q_0) = \lambda w_1 \neg \textbf{laugh}(w_1)(m)
 \end{aligned}$$

- The main contribution of this construction compared to a declarative sentence is the strong exhaustivity. This results in **focus**.
- Under the QUD theory, Caponigro & Davidson analyze the QACs as raising a QUD and resolving it in the same string.

Hello, it's -mI again

- C&D's analysis can be applied to Turkish, X-mI brings about the alternatives (p: beautiful, $\neg$ p: not beautiful), the second instance of X asserts the proposition and exhausts the alternatives.
- The copular requirement is also visible when X is a noun, in which case it needs to be in a relative clause

(23) Arabayı yıka-yan Ali=mi Ali
Car.ACC wash-NOMIN Ali=Q Ali
“It's indeed Ali who is washing the car.”

(24) * Arabayı Ali=mi Ali yıka-dı
Car.ACC Ali=Q Ali wash-PST
Intended: “ALI washed the car.”

Where do we get the gradation?

- C&D's analysis doesn't tell us much about where the intensification meaning comes from since asserting p already eliminates the worlds where $\neg p$ holds
- Ideally, we only need one mechanism that can account for both, if not, then one should be explainable from the other
- Both verbal and adjectival cases can be analyzed as the X constituent applies to very high degree:
 - > in adjectival cases, it's straightforward: I bought a car AND the car is beautiful to very high degree
 - > verbal cases require a graded notion of modality where the degree is about the speaker confidence: $p \wedge$ the speaker is confident about p to a high degree.

Epistemic Intensification

- Certain epistemic adverbs like *really* also carry the same non-cancellable intensification meaning:

(19) # The car is really beautiful, but it's not very beautiful.

- “The contrastivity is a consequence of the fact that assertive propositions come with assumption of truth, and the explicit marking of truth by *really* tends to create a context where the opposite is presupposed. “ (Paradis, 2003)
- The invited inference when *really* takes scope over a scalar property of an adjective is that what is real and true with respect to a scalar property implies “boosting of this property”
- Based on cognitive semantics, no precise explanation of the mechanism.

Enter Slack Operators

- Here, I will follow a slack regulator analysis similar to pragmatic halos (Lasersohn, 1999). It could be argued that XQX constructions force a strict reading of X.
- Similar approaches to analyzing various morphemes as slack operators have been proposed in the literature (Williamson, 1999; for McNabb 2012), where the interpretive effects are very similar to XQX
- Williamson analyzes *definitely* as applying to a proposition (set of worlds), and returning a proposition that is true in all worlds accessible from the actual world, according to some accessibility relation R.
- Here, I will follow Beltrama & Bochnak (2015)'s idea of contextual universal quantification.

- Quantification over contexts of evaluation: rather than making a claim about a property holding to a high degree, *-issimo* and *šému* state that the predicate holds in the context of utterance, as well as in other contexts that may have more stringent standards
- Though they don't discuss why context instead of world for the domain of quantification
- Such operators are analyzed as quantifying over all the contexts similar enough to discourse context (done via an accessibility relation R that takes the current context and returns similar enough contexts) and asserting that in all of the quantified contexts, the property holds.

$$(27) \llbracket \text{mod} \rrbracket^{w,g,c} = \lambda P_c \lambda x. \forall c' [c R c' \rightarrow P(x) \text{ in } c']$$

From Beltrama & Bochnak (2015)

- Adjectival cases:

$$[[\text{tall-m}_1 \text{ tall}]]^c(x) = 1 \text{ iff } \forall c' [c R c' \rightarrow \text{tall}(x) \text{ in } c']$$

$$(28) \llbracket [x\text{-m}_1 x] \rrbracket^{w,g,c} = \lambda P_c \lambda x. \forall c' [c R c' \rightarrow P(x) \text{ in } c']$$

- Verbal cases: $[[x\text{-m}_1 x]]^c(p) = 1 \text{ iff } \forall c' [c R c' \rightarrow p(w) \text{ in } c']$

- Normally, in a regular context where *John is tall* is asserted, the contextual comparison class is usually height of average people. Hence John is tall compared to average people but he might be short compared to basketball players.
- With XQX construction, the assertion quantifies over all similar contexts which can include a context where the comparison class is that of basketball players. Thus, XQX tall would assert that John is tall even in comparison to basketball players.
- There needs some kind of restriction on the possible contexts the accessibility relation selects because XQX tall still doesn't assert 'tall in comparison to giraffes'
- The same operator when applied to verbal cases also gives us the correct meaning, VQV asserts that the proposition holds even in stricter contexts.
- As for contextual requirements, *-issimo* and *šému* require question/answer pairs or elaborations of previous statements. (there is also an expressive component to *-issimo* but I won't discuss this)

Open Questions: Reduplication

- There are other reduplication strategies that might be related to X-m₁ X
- (31) Gup-guzel bir araba al-dim.
 beautiful.redup a car buy-pst.1sg
 ‘I bought a very beautiful car.’
- And in answers, (or cases where ‘whether X’ is the QUD) we obtain the same phenomenon but without *-mI*

(32) A: Can gel-di=mi?
 John come-pst=Q
 ‘Did John come?’

B: Gel-di gel-di.
 come-pst come-pst
 ‘Yes he did (for sure).’

Does this mean that the phenomenon we are dealing with is just a reduplication with a focus particle inbetween?

Behavior of NPI's

- NPI's behave in a peculiar manner wrt. XQX. NPI's are blocked, contrary to their behavior in a normal question

(34)* Can beni hiç sev-iyor=mu sev-iyor
John me.acc any like-prog=q like-prog
Intended: 'John really likes me.' / 'Does John love me at all? Yes.'

(35)* Can beni hiç sev-mi-yor=mu sev-mi-yor
John me.acc any like-neg-prog=q like-neg-prog
Intended: 'John really doesn't like me.' / 'Does John love me at all? No.'

- But they're OK when X is the NPI:

(36) Can beni hiç=mi hiç sev-mi-yor.
John me.acc any=q anylike-neg-prog
'John doesn't like me at all.' / 'John really doesn't like me.'

- While this doesn't directly contradict the Q-A pair analysis, it creates problems.

Outlook & Next Steps

- A slack regulator analysis can account for the XQX meaning.
- XQX quantifies over accessible contexts and asserts in all of them that X holds.
- For verbs, the same mechanism applies, no need to derive one from the other.
- No fully compositional story that is compatible with QAC analysis of C&D though (yet).
- We don't see this XQX effect in a normal Q-A pair between a speaker and an addressee, so whatever contributes this meaning (assuming a unified analysis of -mI) must lie somewhere else. Perhaps it's an effect that is not visible inter-speakers but is only apparent when the speaker asks **and** answers.
- Further research needed

Thank you for listening!

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